# CAT VARC Reading Comprehension Strategy Template

*Passage Mapping Framework, Question Taxonomy, Distractor Traps & Speed-vs-Accuracy Balances*

## 1. The 4-Step Structural Passage Mapping Technique

Read actively for rhetorical architecture and authorial attitude rather than memorizing factual data.

| Reading Step | Time Budget | Action Required | What to Note on Scratch Pad |
|---|---|---|---|
| Step 1: First Paragraph Scan | 45 Seconds | Identify the primary topic and conflicting viewpoints | Topic keyword + Central conflict (e.g. Tech vs Labor) |
| Step 2: Paragraph Transition Tracking | 2 Minutes | Read topic sentences; track pivot words (However, Yet, Furthermore) | 1-line summary per paragraph (P1: View A, P2: Critique, P3: Synthesis) |
| Step 3: Author Tone & Voice Audit | 30 Seconds | Determine whether author is advocacy, skeptical, objective, or critical | Tone descriptor (e.g. cautiously optimistic, satirical) |
| Step 4: Targeted Question Solving | 4 Minutes (4 Qs) | Refer back to passage based on specific structural landmarks | Eliminate 3 wrong options; never fall for verbatim matches |

**STRATEGIC PRINCIPLE:**Pacing Rule: Spend 3 to 3.5 minutes reading and mapping; spend 3.5 to 4 minutes answering all 4 questions.

## 2. The 4 Fatal Distractor Traps Used by CAT Question Setters

Recognize the psychological traps that make wrong answer choices appear attractive.

| Distractor Trap Type | Setter Mechanism | How to Spot & Eliminate It |
|---|---|---|
| The Extreme Language Trap | Uses absolute modifiers: always, never, completely, entirely, solely | Check if author used nuanced qualifiers: often, tends to, largely |
| The Out of Scope (OOS) Trap | Introduces a plausible real-world fact not mentioned in the passage | Ask: "Can I underline textual proof for this assertion in the text?" |
| The Distortion / Half-Truth Trap | Combines true passage keywords with an incorrect causal relationship | Carefully verify the direction of cause and effect |
| The Opposite / Reverse Trap | States the exact inverse of author's view or attributes critique to author | Confirm whether statement reflects the author or author's opponent |

**STRATEGIC PRINCIPLE:**Accuracy Rule: In CAT VARC, eliminating 3 demonstrably flawed options is far more reliable than searching for the

## 3. Passage Selection Matrix: Rank Before Reading

Select passages aligned with your highest comprehension genres to maximize sectional score.

- Tier 1 (High Comfort): Science, Technology, Business, Economics, Environmental Ecology.
- Tier 2 (Moderate Comfort): History, Politics, Sociology, International Relations, Psychology.
- Tier 3 (High Cognitive Load): 19th Century Philosophy, Abstract Art Criticism, Post-Modern Literary Theory.
- Strategy: Read the first 2 sentences of all 4 passages; sequence your attempts Tier 1 -> Tier 2 -> Tier 3.